

Nvidia's 550B Nemotron beats top human coder at IOI 2026

By [Alexis Dufresne](#) · Published September 3, 2026 at 03:54 UTC · Updated September 3, 2026 at 04:00 UTC

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TL;DR

- Nemotron-3-Ultra-CC scored 535.4 out of 600 at IOI 2026, above the top human's 498.27 and the 361.12 gold threshold.
- The 550B-parameter Ultra-CC was trained with supervised fine-tuning alone on 22,000 curated competitive-programming problems.
- Authors call it the first AI system to outscore the highest-scoring human on an IOI problem set.

EDITOR'S NOTE

A single-team Nvidia preprint, but if the setup survives scrutiny the reasoning-model race now has a public IOI number every rival lab has to match or explain away.

Nvidia researchers report that their 550-billion-parameter Nemotron-3-Ultra-CC scored 535.4 out of 600 at IOI 2026, above the top human contestant's 498.27 and well above the gold threshold of 361.12.

The claim comes from a new [arXiv preprint](#) by Aleksander Ficek and colleagues, describing an end-to-end pipeline of curated problems,

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highest-scoring human contestant on an IOI problem set, the authors write.

Two models were trained on 22,000 curated problems: Nemotron-3-Nano-CC (30B-A3B) with both SFT and RL, and Nemotron-3-Ultra-CC (550B-A55B) with SFT alone. A test-time strategy called GenCorrect "iteratively generates, evaluates, and refines diverse solutions." On IOI 2025, Nano-CC went from 130 points to 291 after post-training, then to 468 with GenCorrect, exceeding the gold threshold of 438.3. Ultra-CC reached 502.

The IOI 2026 run was prospective. The paper says the competition-specific Ultra-CC system operated "under the same time, internet-access, and submission constraints as human contestants." It names no human contestant, publishes no per-problem breakdown, and gives no compute budget.

This is a research claim from Nvidia's own team about its own model, not an independently adjudicated result.

EDITOR'S TAKE

Watch whether IOI organizers or an independent group confirm the same-constraints claim; without that, the 535.4 stays a vendor-reported number rather than a benchmarked result.

- Who is the human contestant behind the 498.27, and how tightly clustered were the top human scores in the 2026 field?

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